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Module: Child and Youth Misbehaviour

Module Code: CMY2603

Semester: Semester 1

Assessment: Assessment 1

Year: 2026

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1. INTRODUCTION

Youth misbehaviour such as aggression, violence and delinquency is influenced by a variety of risk factors in the South African context. Youth misbehaviour refers to behaviour by children and adolescents that goes against societal norms and legal expectations, including criminal acts, violence and other disruptive behaviours. These behaviours are influenced by multiple social, economic and environmental conditions that affect young people during their development.

Risk factors refer to conditions that increase the likelihood that young people will engage in problematic behaviour later in life. According to the CMY2603 study guide, a risk factor is any variable that increases the probability of youth offending or antisocial behaviour (Maree, 2018). These risk factors may occur at different levels, including the family, community, school and individual level.

Research indicates that South African children who grow up in disadvantaged or unstable environments are more likely to engage in aggressive or criminal behaviour (Ramakuela, Babolia & Mashau, 2021). Understanding these risk factors is important because it helps explain why some young people become involved in problematic behaviour and how such behaviour can be prevented.

This assignment discusses five major risk factors associated with youth misbehaviour in South Africa and explains how they contribute to aggressive, violent or criminal behaviour among young people. It also examines how Eurocentric historical and social influences have shaped the socialisation and disciplining of children in South Africa and how these influences may contribute to youth misbehaviour.

2. QUESTION 1: RISK FACTORS ASSOCIATED WITH YOUTH MISBEHAVIOUR IN SOUTH AFRICA

2.1 Socio-economic deprivation

Socio-economic deprivation, particularly poverty and unemployment, is one of the major factors contributing to youth misbehaviour in South Africa. Poverty places significant pressure on families and communities, often resulting in stress, frustration and limited opportunities for young people. When parents are unemployed, they may struggle to provide basic needs for their children, which can negatively affect children's emotional and social development.

The study guide explains that economic inequality and relative deprivation are widely recognised as factors that contribute to crime and youth offending (Maree, 2018). Youth who grow up in poverty-stricken communities may experience feelings of exclusion or deprivation, which may increase the likelihood of criminal behaviour.

Research also indicates that many youths from disadvantaged communities resort to crime or aggressive behaviour as a way of coping with poverty and lack of opportunities (Ramakuela, Babolia & Mashau, 2021). For example, in many townships, teenagers who have completed school but cannot find employment may join gangs or engage in criminal activities in order to survive. Bouwer (2005) further explains that growing up in communities characterised by poverty and unemployment can make crime and gangsterism appear to be alternative routes to identity and survival.

2.2 Family conflict and dysfunctional homes

Family environment plays an important role in shaping children's behaviour. Children who grow up in violent or dysfunctional homes face a higher risk of engaging in misbehaviour. According to the study guide, family-related risk factors include family violence, lack of parental supervision, family conflict and unstable family structures (Maree, 2018).

Domestic violence, parental substance abuse, harsh punishment and marital conflict can negatively affect a child's psychological development. Ramakuela, Babolia and Mashau (2021) explain that family conflicts, divorce or separation, poverty and harsh punishments are common realities in many households and can contribute to youth violence.

When caregivers fail to provide warmth, guidance or consistent discipline, children may develop feelings of anger or resentment. These emotional difficulties can lead to acting-out behaviour. For example, children who experience abuse or neglect at home may seek support and belonging outside the family environment, sometimes turning to delinquent peer groups.

2.3 Delinquent peer groups

Association with delinquent peers is another significant risk factor associated with youth misbehaviour. During adolescence, young people spend more time with their friends than with their families, and peer groups often play a significant role in shaping behaviour.

The study guide explains that youth misbehaviour often occurs in group settings and that peer pressure can influence adolescents to engage in risky or criminal behaviour (Maree, 2018). Adolescents may imitate the behaviour of their friends in order to gain acceptance within the group.

According to Ramakuela, Babolia and Mashau (2021), adolescents who spend time with aggressive or criminal peers are more likely to imitate such behaviour. In many South African communities, gang culture fills the gap left by weak family supervision. Learners may

become involved with older gang members who teach them activities such as robbery, drug dealing or violence.

2.4 Exposure to drugs and alcohol

Exposure to drugs and alcohol is another important factor that contributes to youth misbehaviour. The availability and misuse of substances can lower inhibitions and increase aggressive behaviour among young people.

The study guide highlights that tobacco and alcohol are among the most commonly used substances among South African youth, while marijuana is one of the most frequently used illegal drugs (Peltzer, 2003). Substance abuse can impair judgement and increase impulsive behaviour, which may result in violence or criminal activity.

Research confirms that substance abuse is strongly linked to violent behaviour among adolescents (Ramakuela, Babolia & Mashau, 2021). For example, adolescents under the influence of alcohol may become involved in fights, bullying or vandalism.

2.5 Violent community and school environments

Growing up in communities where violence is common can normalise aggressive behaviour among young people. According to the study guide, South Africa has high levels of crime and violence, and young people are often both victims and perpetrators of violent behaviour (Morodi, Doorewaard & Gahler, 2019).

Constant exposure to violence can desensitise children and teach them that aggression is an acceptable way to resolve conflicts. In addition, violence in schools can also influence youth behaviour. Schools where bullying, gang activity and violence occur regularly may contribute to aggressive behaviour among learners.

Children who experience or witness violence are more likely to become involved in violent behaviour themselves later in life.

2.6 Conclusion

In conclusion, youth misbehaviour in South Africa is influenced by a combination of risk factors including poverty, family dysfunction, negative peer influence, substance abuse and exposure to violence. These factors often interact with one another, creating environments in which aggressive or criminal behaviour becomes more likely. Addressing youth misbehaviour therefore requires a comprehensive approach that focuses on improving socio-economic conditions, strengthening families and promoting safer communities

3. QUESTION 2: EUROCENTRIC INFLUENCE AND SOCIALISATION OF CHILDREN

3.1 Definition of acculturation

Acculturation refers to the process through which one culture adopts the customs, values and beliefs of another culture through continuous interaction. According to Nickerson (2024), acculturation occurs when individuals or communities adopt aspects of a different culture, often as a result of colonisation, migration or social influence.

In the South African context, acculturation occurred when European colonial powers introduced Western cultural values, educational systems and disciplinary practices that influenced African societies.

3.2 Eurocentric missionary education and discipline

Eurocentric influence has played a major role in shaping the upbringing of children and youth in South Africa. According to the CMY2603 study guide, colonial influence introduced Western cultural practices that affected the lives and development of many children in South Africa (Morodi, Doorewaard & Gahler, 2019).

During colonial times, Christian missionaries introduced formal schooling and Western moral values. These missionary schools promoted obedience, discipline and Western cultural norms while often suppressing traditional African forms of socialisation. Van Wyk and Chigamba (2019) explain that corporal punishment became widely accepted through missionary education systems.

In many traditional African societies, children were taught values through storytelling, guidance from elders and community mentorship rather than harsh physical punishment. The introduction of Western disciplinary methods therefore represented a shift from traditional child-rearing practices..

3.3 Apartheid policies and family disruption

Apartheid policies also had a major impact on the socialisation of children in South Africa. The apartheid government enforced migrant labour systems and forced removals, which separated many families. As a result, many children grew up without consistent parental supervision.

Hall and Posel (2019) describe apartheid policies as having disrupted family structures and weakened traditional support systems within communities. Without stable family environments, many young people became more vulnerable to negative peer influences and criminal behaviour.

3.4 Contemporary Eurocentric influence in schools

Even after the end of apartheid, Eurocentric influences remain present in South African education systems. Many schools continue to follow Western curricula and authority structures that may not fully reflect African cultural traditions.

According to Singh (2024), post-apartheid classrooms often continue to privilege Western cultural norms, sometimes at the expense of African identities. This cultural mismatch may create feelings of alienation among learners.

When young people feel disconnected from their cultural identity or the education system, they may respond with frustration, rebellion or disruptive behaviour.

3.5 Conclusion

Eurocentric influence has significantly shaped the socialisation and disciplining of children in South Africa. Colonial education, missionary influence and apartheid policies introduced Western cultural values that altered traditional African child-rearing practices and family structures. These historical and social changes have created cultural tensions and social challenges that may contribute to youth misbehaviour. Understanding these influences is therefore important for addressing youth violence and promoting positive development among young people.

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